ILLUSTRATED REFERENCE REPORT

Shiro Kuramata

1934–1991. The Japanese designer who spent thirty years trying to make furniture weigh nothing.



The signature piece. How High the Moon, 1986. Nickel-plated expanded steel mesh. Produced by Vitra.



The designer. Shiro Kuramata.

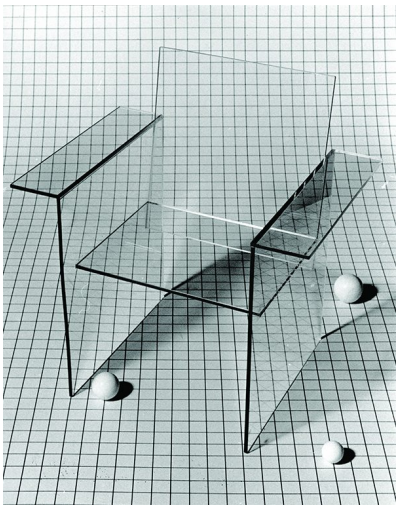
Shiro Kuramata is the rare designer whose best pieces are instantly recognisable and still hard to explain. A chair made of six sheets of glass and nothing else. An armchair of nickel-plated steel mesh that reads as a drawing of a chair rather than a chair. A block of clear acrylic with red paper roses frozen inside it.

He worked in Tokyo for his entire career, built most of his reputation through interiors that were torn down within a few years, and was dead at 56. Yet he is one of a handful of Japanese designers with a secure place in the Western canon, collected by MoMA, the Met and the Vitra Design Museum, and the subject of a 600-piece Phaidon monograph.

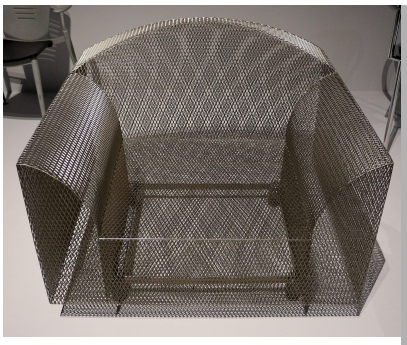
This report is a primer: who he was, what he was trying to do, the pieces you should know with pictures of each, and the lenses from his work that are worth stealing. Sources and image credits are at the end.

WHY HE MATTERS

- **He treated materials as the idea.** Acrylic, glass, expanded steel mesh and terrazzo were not finishes applied to a form. Each piece asks what a chair or a cabinet becomes when it is made from one industrial material and nothing else.
- **He pursued weightlessness and transparency as a lifelong theme.** Gravity was something to escape. His pieces try to float, dissolve, or exist as outlines.
- **He bridged Japanese minimalism and Italian postmodernism.** A founding member of Memphis in 1981, he brought restraint to a movement known for noise, and brought colour and play back to Tokyo.
- **He designed from memory and dreams, not from function.** He kept dream journals, named chairs after jazz standards and film characters, and said openly that he was interested in furniture that is not meant to be used.
- **His influence is quiet but everywhere.** Cantilevered shelves with folded clothes in a fashion boutique, cast resin with objects suspended inside, mesh furniture, and the idea that a shop interior can be an artwork all trace back to him.



Glass. Glass Chair, 1976. Six panes of glass, nothing else.



Mesh. How High the Moon, 1986–87. The mesh up close.



Resin. Miss Blanche, 1988. Roses cast in acrylic.

LIFE IN BRIEF

Born in Tokyo in 1934, Kuramata grew up through the war and the occupation. The shortage years left him with a lasting fascination for new, abundant industrial materials. He found design almost by accident, working at the Teikoku Kizai furniture factory in 1954, then trained at the Kuwasawa Design Institute, the most progressive design school in Japan at the time.

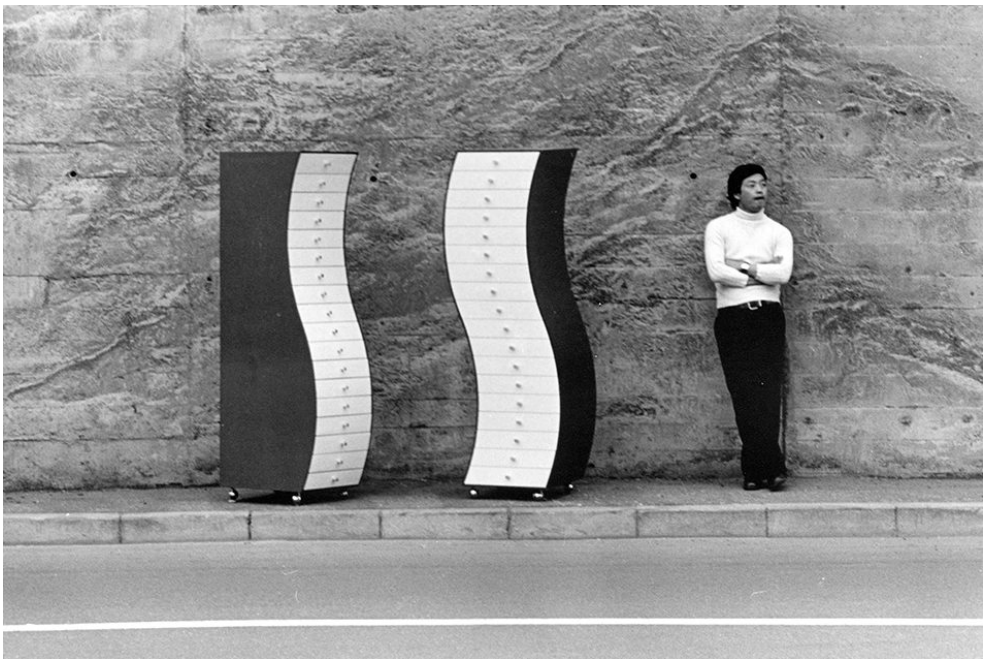
His first decade was spent in the display departments of Tokyo department stores, learning to make retail spaces feel like something more than shops. He opened his own office in 1965 and never left Tokyo, though by the late 1980s he had a second studio in Paris and clients on three continents.



1979. Kuramata in 1979. Photo by Kazumi Kurigami.

1934	Born 29 November in Tokyo.
1953	Finishes a woodworking course at Tokyo Metropolitan Polytechnic High School.
1954–56	Teikoku Kizai furniture factory; then interior design at the Kuwasawa Design Institute.
1957–63	Display and interior departments of Tokyo department stores, including San-Ai in Ginza.
1965	Opens Kuramata Design Office in Tokyo. Begins the acrylic experiments that define his early work.
1970	*Furniture in Irregular Forms, Side 1 and Side 2*: the wavy plywood chests that first bring him international attention.

1972	*Oba-Q* lamps. Mainichi Industrial Design Award.
1976	*Glass Chair*. First Issey Miyake boutique, in Minami-Aoyama; the collaboration runs for the rest of his life.
1981	Invited by Ettore Sottsass to be a founding member of Memphis in Milan. Receives the Japan Cultural Design Prize.
1986	*How High the Moon*, later put into production by Vitra.
1988	*Miss Blanche*. Opens a Paris studio. Kiyotomo sushi bar, Tokyo.
1990	Made a Chevalier of the Ordre des Arts et des Lettres by the French Ministry of Culture.
1991	Dies 1 February in Tokyo of heart failure caused by myocarditis, aged 56.



1970. Kuramata beside Furniture in Irregular Forms, Side 1 and Side 2, 1970. The pieces that made his name abroad.

THE IDEAS



Dream journal. A page from the sketchbook Words, Dreams, Memories, 1980s.

Weightlessness. Kuramata said he wanted to be free of gravity, and almost every mature piece is an attempt at it. The *Glass Chair* has no visible structure. *How High the Moon* keeps the silhouette of a plump club chair but replaces all its mass with a mesh you can see through. *Miss Blanche* holds flowers mid-air. He also hated seams, reportedly calling them the hardest part of any object because they reveal that the thing is finite.

Memory and dreams. He kept dream journals and sketchbooks, one titled *Words, Dreams, Memories*. Childhood smells, the sound of a record, a line from a play were his raw material.

Transparency and immateriality. Acrylic in the 1960s and 70s, glass in the mid-70s, expanded metal from the mid-80s. Each is a material that lets light and space pass through. The goal was never a clear chair for its own sake; it was an object that reads as an outline of itself, an apparition in the room rather than a presence.

Names as mood. Many works are named after jazz standards (*How High the Moon*, *Sing Sing Sing*, *Begin the Beguine*, *Apple Honey*, *Twilight Time*) or after records themselves (*Side 1*, *Side 2*). *Miss Blanche* is named for Blanche DuBois in *A Streetcar Named Desire*. *Oba-Q* is a cartoon ghost.

Function as a side effect. Everything he made works. The 49-drawer cabinet opens, the glass chair holds roughly 100 kilograms, the seven-handed clock tells time. But function was not the starting point. He described furniture that simply happens to manifest as furniture, and most of his drawer pieces were made without a client.

> *“I am interested in furniture that is not intended to be used, but simply happens to manifest as furniture.”*
>
> Shiro Kuramata, quoted in the 2023 Setagaya Art Museum retrospective

> *“Memories, including the dream experiences I had, for me, constitute an infinite cosmos.”*
>
> Shiro Kuramata, from his notebooks

> *“Blanche DuBois herself is fake.”*
>
> Kuramata, on why the roses in Miss Blanche had to be artificial

KEY WORKS

In order, from the acrylic experiments of the late 1960s to the resin pieces finished months before his death.



Luminous Chair, 1969. White acrylic shell with a light inside: a chair that is also a lamp. Ishimaru, edition of 30.



Revolving Cabinet, 1970. Twenty red acrylic drawers that fan out around a steel spine. Still made by Cappellini.



Side 1, 1970. Stained ash and lacquer; the wave rises. Reissued by Cappellini from 1986.



Side 2, 1970. The twin, bending the other way. From Cappellini's Progetti Compiuti catalogue.



Side 1, detail. Drawer detail. Thin plywood layers make the curve possible.



Oba-Q lamp, 1972. A heated acrylic sheet draped over a pole and left to set. Named after the manga ghost Q-Taro. First shown March 1972.



Oba-Q, unlit. The same lamp unlit, showing the natural drape. Produced by Yamagiwa and Ishimaru.



Glass Chair, 1976. Six panes bonded with Photobond 100, a UV-cured glue new in 1976, so the joints vanish.



Glass Chair, front. Front view. His answer to the furniture he found disappointing in 2001: A Space Odyssey.



Glass Chair, side. Side view. No frame, no fixings; it holds about 100 kilograms.



Dinah chest, 1970. A tall column of drawers in painted steel and wood. One of several drawer pieces made without a client.



Yamagiwa cabinet, c. 1983. Double-sided maple cabinet with integrated table for the Yamagiwa Livina building, Akihabara. Aoshima Shoten.



Kyoto table, 1983. Star Piece terrazzo: coloured glass shards in concrete, which he called the debris of memory. Made for Memphis.



How High the Moon, 1986. A generous armchair silhouette with all its weight removed. Toyama Prefectural Museum of Art and Design.



How High the Moon sofa. Early two-seater, 1988, chrome-plated. Terada Tekkojo for Idée, Tokyo.



How High the Moon, Vitra. The Vitra version. The mesh creates a moiré that shifts as you move.



Sing Sing Sing, 1985. The first mesh chair, for XO in France. Chrome-plated steel pipe and expanded mesh; a sketch in metal.



Piacere chair, c. 1988. Acrylic and painted steel chair from the Piacere coffee shop, Tokyo. A sketch of a chair.



Hydrogen Dream, c. 1988. Small stainless steel and brass lamp produced by Yamagiwa.



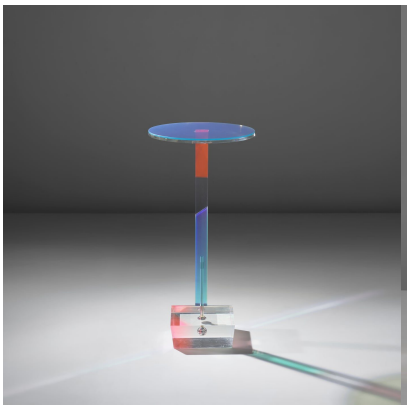
Miss Blanche, 1988. Paper roses poured into clear resin so they float in the seat. Real roses burned in the acrylic. Only 56 made.



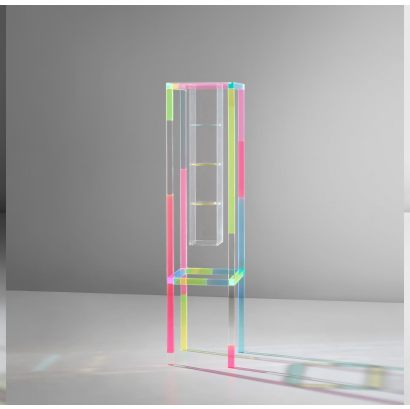
Miss Blanche. Toyama Prefectural Museum of Art and Design. First shown at KAGU, Tokyo, 1988.



Miss Blanche, installed. On view in a darkened gallery, where the roses appear to hang in air.



Placebo side table, c. 1989. Coloured acrylic and glass side table. Ishimaru, glass by Mihoya.



Cabinet de Curiosité, 1989. Coloured and clear acrylic. A cabinet drawn in neon lines. Ishimaru, edition of 40.



Acrylic Stool with Feathers, 1990. Mallard feathers suspended in cast acrylic, designed for the Spiral boutique, Roppongi.

Not pictured. *Begin the Beguine* (1985), a bentwood chair burned and rebuilt in mesh as an homage to Josef Hoffmann, which holds his auction record; and *Twilight Time* (1985, XO), a stepped glass table on three mesh cones. Images of these are hard to find online outside the Phaidon catalogue.

INTERIORS: THE WORK THAT DISAPPEARED

Kuramata designed over 350 interiors: bars, restaurants, clubs and shops in Tokyo and later abroad. Almost none survive. He knew they were temporary and designed them that way. Three stand out.



Kiyotomo. Kiyotomo sushi bar, Shinbashi, Tokyo, 1988, reassembled inside M+ in Hong Kong. A granite counter under a double-vaulted ceiling of cedar on one side and backlit acrylic on the other, with Ingo Maurer's YaYaHo lights above.



Kiyotomo, facade. The entrance: a bright blue wall set at an angle into a dark steel facade.



Kiyotomo, interior. Inside. Cedar panels with gaps accurate to three millimetres.

- **Kiyotomo sushi bar (1988).** Opened by a young chef, closed in the early 1990s after the bubble burst, and left vacant for years. M+ acquired it in 2014, with craftsmen from Ishimaru, his long-time fabricator, dismantling and reinstalling it. Conservators found three layers of blue paint at the entrance, suggesting Kuramata changed his mind on site.

- **Issey Miyake boutiques (1976 onward).** He designed dozens of Miyake shops, from Minami-Aoyama in Tokyo to Bergdorf Goodman in New York and Paris. His innovation was to lay garments flat on thin cantilevered shelves rather than hang them, so the clothes read as objects and the shop as a gallery.
- **Oblomov bar, Il Palazzo, Fukuoka (1989).** Commissioned by Aldo Rossi for his hotel. Kuramata made a monumental floor lamp for it with synthetic roses cast into the acrylic shaft, a cousin of Miss Blanche.



Miyake, Aoyama. Issey Miyake Men, Aoyama, Tokyo. A 1980s Kuramata interior that survives largely intact, with a steel cable strung along one wall.

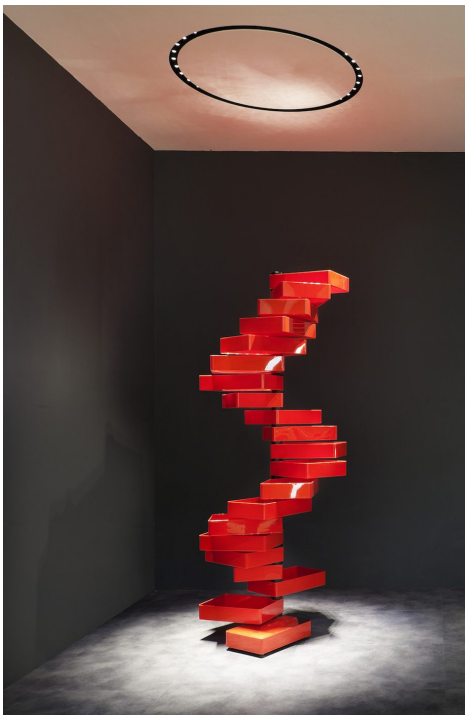


Oblomov lamp. Unique floor lamp from the Oblomov restaurant, Fukuoka, 1989. Acrylic resin, aluminium, synthetic roses.

MEMPHIS AND SOTTSASS

Kuramata met Ettore Sottsass in the 1970s and the two became close. When Sottsass launched Memphis in Milan in 1981 he invited Kuramata as a founding member, the only Japanese designer in the group. Kuramata's Memphis pieces (*Imperial*, *Kyoto*, *Sally*) share the movement's appetite for colour and surprising material but keep his stillness.

The exchange ran both ways. Memphis gave him an international stage and the permission to be playful; his restraint gave Memphis one of its few quiet voices. He later called Sottsass his maestro. The 21_21 Design Sight exhibition in Tokyo in 2010 was devoted to the pair.

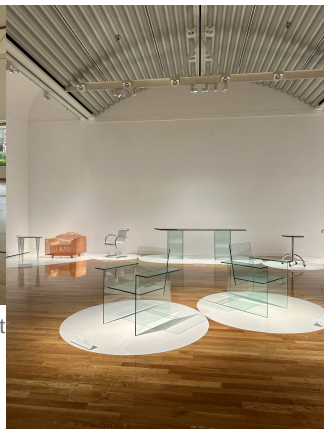


Revolving, red. Revolving Cabinet in Cappellini's current production.

WHERE TO SEE HIM



A Microcosmos of Memory. Setagaya Art Museum, Tokyo, 2023.



Installation view. The glass pieces in the round.



Installation view. Acrylic furniture on white islands.

- **Collections:** Museum of Modern Art and the Metropolitan Museum, New York; SFMOMA; Museum of Fine Arts, Boston; Museum of Fine Arts, Houston; Nelson-Atkins, Kansas City; Philadelphia Museum of Art; Museum of Arts and Design, New York; Centre Pompidou, Paris; Vitra Design Museum, Weil am Rhein; Hara Museum, Tokyo; M+, Hong Kong.

- **Retrospectives:** Hara Museum, Tokyo (1996); SFMOMA (1997); 21_21 Design Sight, Tokyo, with Sottsass (2010); Vitra Design Museum Gallery, *Design as Poetry* (2013–14); *The Work of Shiro Kuramata: A Microcosmos of Memory*, Setagaya Art Museum, then Toyama and the National Museum of Modern Art, Kyoto (November 2023 to August 2024), the first Tokyo solo show in over twenty years, with his dream journals on view.
- **In production:** Vitra (*How High the Moon*), Cappellini (*Side 1*, *Side 2*, *Revolving Cabinet*, *Pyramid*), Glas Italia (*Glass Chair* and table reissues), XO (*Sing Sing Sing*). Ishimaru in Tokyo cast the original resin pieces.
- **At auction:** a *Miss Blanche* sold at Christie's London in October 2007 for £156,500, about three times its high estimate. A *Luminous Chair* made £35,560 at Phillips in 2024 against a £5,000 estimate.

LENSES WORTH STEALING

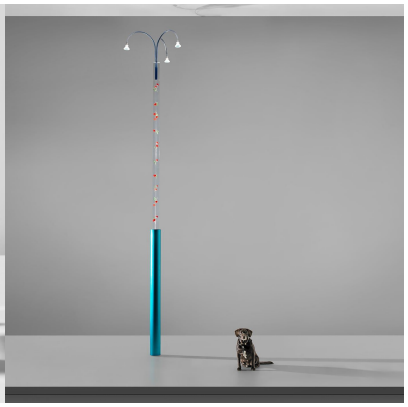
- **Pick one material and push it to its limit.** The Glass Chair is only glass. Mesh chairs are only mesh. The constraint is the concept.
- **Keep the familiar silhouette, remove the mass.** *How High the Moon* works because it is recognisably an armchair. The surprise is in what is missing, not in a new shape.
- **Hide the seams.** A joint that disappears changes how an object feels. Invest in the adhesive, the weld, the tolerance.
- **Name things after feelings.** A jazz standard or a film character gives an object a mood before anyone touches it.
- **Let display be the design.** The Miyake shelves prove a store fixture can define a brand more than the architecture around it.
- **Suspend something fragile in something permanent.** Roses in resin, feathers in acrylic. Contrast of the ephemeral and the fixed is a reliable source of emotion.
- **Design from a dream journal.** Keep one. His best ideas came from memory, not from a brief.



Lines in space. Cabinet de Curiosité, another angle.



Feathers in acrylic. Acrylic Stool with Feathers, side.



Roses in resin. Oblomov lamp, full height.

READ AND WATCH

- Deyan Sudjic, *Shiro Kuramata* (Phaidon, 2013). Two volumes in an acrylic slipcase: a biography and a catalogue of all 600-plus works. The definitive reference.
- *Shiro Kuramata 1934–1991*, Hara Museum of Contemporary Art exhibition catalogue (1996).
- *The Work of Shiro Kuramata: A Microcosmos of Memory*, Setagaya Art Museum catalogue (2023), which reproduces his dream journals and texts.
- M+ magazine: “From the Collections: Lamp (Oba-Q)” and “The Kiyotomo Sushi Bar: A Journey from Tokyo to Hong Kong” (video, 7 min).
- Ted Loos, “Shiro Kuramata,” *Introspective* (1stdibs), an accessible profile built around an interview with Sudjic.

SOURCES

- Wikipedia, Shiro Kuramata: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Shiro_Kuramata
- Wallpaper*, Shiro Kuramata's multilayered cosmos on view in Tokyo: https://wallpaper.com/design-interiors/shiro-kuramata-exhibition
- Friedman Benda, The Work of Shiro Kuramata: A Microcosmos of Memory: https://www.friedmanbenda.com/exhibitions/the-work-of-shiro-kuramata-a-microcosmos-of-memory/
- 1stdibs Introspective, Shiro Kuramata: https://www.1stdibs.com/introspective-magazine/shiro-kuramata
- Tokyo Art Beat, Liberated Materials: Clearly Kuramata: https://www.tokyoartbeat.com/en/articles/-/liberated-materials-clearly-kuramata
- M+ magazine, 1980s design encapsulated within a sushi bar; From the Collections: Lamp (Oba-Q): https://www.mplus.org.hk/en/magazine/
- Phillips lot pages for Side One, Luminous, Glass Chair, Cabinet de Curiosité, Acrylic Stool, Kyoto, Placebo, Hydrogen Dream, Oblomov lamp, Piacere chair, Dinah, Yamagiwa cabinet and How High the Moon sofa: https://phillips.com/artist/8986/shiro-kuramata
- SFMOMA, Nelson-Atkins, Met, Centre Pompidou and Vitra Design Museum collection records.
- Sotheby's lot notes for Miss Blanche (2018) and Twilight Time (2015).

IMAGE CREDITS

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San Francisco Museum of Modern Art collection photograph: The signature piece.

Portrait courtesy of Phaidon Press, via John Pawson's journal: The designer.

1stdibs Introspective, photo courtesy Phaidon: Glass.

Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA: Mesh; Side 2, 1970; Miss Blanche, installed; Kiyotomo.

Vitra Design Museum, photo Steve Double: Resin.

1stdibs Introspective, photo Kazumi Kurigami, courtesy Phaidon: 1979.

Cappellini archive, via Mohd magazine: 1970.

Photo Tadayuki Minamoto, Kuramata Design Office, via Wallpaper*: Dream journal.

Phillips auction catalogue photograph: Luminous Chair, 1969; Side 1, 1970; Side 1, detail; Glass Chair, 1976; Glass Chair, front; Glass Chair, side; Dinah chest, 1970; Yamagiwa cabinet, c. 1983; Kyoto table, 1983; How High the Moon sofa; Piacere chair, c. 1988; Hydrogen Dream, c. 1988; Placebo side table, c. 1989; Cabinet de Curiosité, 1989; Acrylic Stool with Feathers, 1990; Oblomov lamp; Lines in space; Feathers in acrylic; Roses in resin.

SFMOMA collection photograph: Revolving Cabinet, 1970; Oba-Q lamp, 1972; Miss Blanche, 1988.

1stdibs listing photograph: Oba-Q, unlit.

Photo Ryohei Yanagihara, Kuramata Design Office, via Wallpaper*: How High the Moon, 1986.

Nelson-Atkins Museum of Art collection photograph: How High the Moon, Vitra.

High Museum of Art, Atlanta, collection photograph: Sing Sing Sing, 1985.

Friedman Benda, Kuramata Design Office: Miss Blanche.

Dezeen, photo courtesy M+: Kiyotomo, facade; Kiyotomo, interior.

Retail & Leisure International: Miyake, Aoyama.

Cappellini, via Mohd magazine: Revolving, red.

Courtesy Setagaya Art Museum, via Wallpaper*: A Microcosmos of Memory; Installation view.